

France

Competition Authority

In 2020, the French Competition Authority ('Autorité') decided to create a dedicated digital unit in order to strengthen its resources in digital areas.²⁰ Launched in September of the same year, the digital economy unit is composed of four people (including two data scientists) and, among its objectives, one of them is to develop new digital and computational tools allowing the Autorité to deepen its understanding of the digital sectors and to facilitate the works of the cases handlers.

The Autorité is proud to be part of the Stanford Computational Antitrust and to have contributed to its first annual report. The following presents what has been done since then.

The Autorité, in collaboration with CodeX Computation Antitrust, has published on its website the first interactive network graph tool capable of identifying within the Autorité's publications (*i.e.*, the decisions, opinions and interim measures published between 2009 and 2021) the references to its other publications and to represent these interconnections in a graph.²¹

Designed for the antitrust community (case handlers, scholars, lawyers, etc.), it takes the form of a network graph in which the Autorité's publications are represented and connected with each other by their citations. It allows the identification of the interconnections between different publications at a first glance and gives an overview of the Autorité's antitrust cases. It also can be used to:

- Get a visual overview of French antitrust cases;
- Create a bibliography for research projects (starting with a reference or a sector, the user will be able to use the tool to fill in the gaps and find closely related publications;
- Identify all key publications: users can visualize important French antitrust publications based on their impact on newer publications (number of citations) and the importance of web audience;
- Discover the most relevant prior and derivative works.

²⁰ Autorité de la concurrence, *The Autorité Creates a Digital Economy Unit*, <https://perma.cc/6742-UKUX> (last accessed June 7, 2023).

²¹ Digital Economy Unit & CodeX: Stable version 1, <https://sen-codex.dev/> (last accessed June 7, 2023).

An article explains all the process and the visualization tool developed by the Autorité.²² Moreover, the entirety of the data are accessible as open data on the Autorité's GitHub.²³

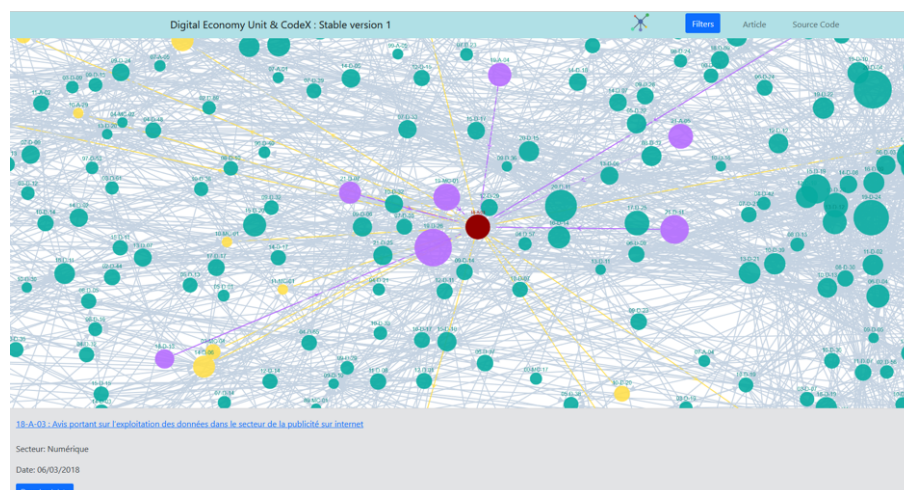


Figure I: Highlight of opinion 18-A-03 in the tool and its related publications²⁴

The Autorité is also still involved in the second phase of the DATACROSS project, which aims to improve the prototype tool assessing corruption risk factors in firms' ownership structure (risks of collusion, corruption, and money laundering in the European single market).²⁵ It will be useful for collaboration with other agencies in the field of cartel detection. In parallel, the Autorité has also begun working on its own detection tool of collusion in public procurements based on the open-access databases available (DECP, BOAMP, INPI, etc.) combined with in-house indicators (to be built).

Finally, the digital economy unit is currently developing a variety of automated tools for on-going cases investigated by the competition units within the Autorité. We will share the technology we have developed for those cases in due course.

²² Yann Guthmann, Adrien Frumence & Camille Hoogterp, *Deploying Network Analysis in Antitrust Law*, <https://www.autoritedelaconurrence.fr/sites/default/files/2023-01/Stanford-Computational-Antitrust-en.pdf> (last accessed June 7, 2023).

²³ Autorité de la concurrence, *CodeX Networkgraph*, https://github.com/AutoriteDeLaConurrence/publication_sen-codex_networkgraph (last accessed June 7, 2023).

²⁴ Opinion 18-A-03 of March 06, 2018 (*Data Processing in the Online Advertising Sector*).

²⁵ Transcrime, *DATACROSS II Kick-off Meeting*, <https://www.transcrime.it/en/datacross-ii-kick-off-meeting/> (last accessed June 7, 2023).